



Full Price for an Empty Camp

Student copy (project or hand out)

On June 9, 2026, the Government Accountability Office, the nonpartisan agency that audits federal spending for Congress, released a report detailing waste and safety failures at Camp East Montana, the nation's largest immigration detention facility. The following is a guest commentary published in a national newspaper, in which the writer addresses fellow taxpayers about what the audit found.

1 On June 9 the Government Accountability Office, the agency Congress assigns to audit federal spending, published what its auditors found at Camp East Montana, the largest immigration detention facility the federal government has ever run. The camp opened in August 2025 on Fort Bliss, an Army post in El Paso, Texas, with room for 5,000 people and an operating contract worth \$1.3 billion. That money is ours. The auditors went to see what it bought.

2 For its first two weeks, from August 1 to August 15, 2025, the camp held no detained people at all. The Army, under terms the government itself had signed, paid the full cost anyway: guards for no one, medical care for no one, transportation for no one, meals for no one. Those two empty weeks cost \$11.5 million. Roughly \$423,000 more went to wasted meals between mid-August and the end of September, because the contract required full meal and service payments for 5,000 people no matter how many were actually there. The payments always arrived in full; the people never did. At the end of February 2026, the camp built for 5,000 held about 1,600.

3 The auditors also measured the camp against the government's own detention standards and found failures the report described as "risking the safety and security of detained noncitizens and staff." When a camp opened without perimeter security cameras, without outdoor recreation space, without anywhere for the people inside to meet a lawyer or a family member; when a loaded firearm went missing; when a man with tuberculosis was housed with the general population in November because screening procedures were not followed, and not one detainee with HIV or diabetes had a treatment plan on file, that camp was failing the one duty that justifies holding anyone at all, which is keeping the people in its custody safe. We paid full price again. At least four people have died at Camp East Montana. The local coroner ruled one of those deaths a homicide, and the report notes that "evidence associated with the incident was missing or destroyed."

4 Some of this has since moved. In April 2026, ICE, the federal agency that runs immigration detention, ended the operating contract early, a step the government may take without claiming anyone broke the rules, and chose a new contractor to run the camp. The auditors issued four recommendations, two to ICE, one to the Department of the Army, and one to the Department of Homeland Security, and estimated that tens of millions of dollars could still be saved through September 2026.

5 The report's warning reaches past El Paso. Thirty-eight billion dollars is planned for the Department of Homeland Security to convert warehouses into new detention facilities, and the auditors warned that this camp's failures could become the blueprint for that spending. That is roughly thirty times the contract that just failed. We funded the first camp without looking; we owe the next ones the attention this one never got. Ask what a contract pays for when the beds are empty. Ask who checks the standards before the buses arrive. The auditors looked once. The next look belongs to us.

AP-style multiple choice:

1. In the third paragraph, the writer follows the long sentence beginning "When a camp opened" with the short sentence "We paid full price again." primarily to
 - A) turn the catalogue of safety failures into a shared financial complicity the reader cannot stand apart from
 - B) emphasize the thoroughness of the auditors' accounting of the empty weeks
 - C) concede that the camp's conditions matter less to the report than the contract's cost
 - D) shift the essay from the auditors' findings to the writer's firsthand experience of the camp
2. In the second paragraph, the repetition of "for no one" in "guards for no one, medical care for no one, transportation for no one, meals for no one" serves primarily to
 - A) mock the contractors who staffed the empty facility
 - B) suggest that the services were poorly delivered even when detained people were present
 - C) exaggerate the camp's emptiness beyond what the audit documents
 - D) itemize each paid-for service against the same absence so the waste is felt item by item rather than as one abstract sum

Discussion questions:

1. The writer repeatedly says "we" paid and closes by handing "the next look" to the reader. What does the piece gain, and what does it risk, by implicating its audience instead of blaming only the agencies?
2. The piece argues forcefully about waste and safety while never taking a side on immigration policy itself. Where exactly does the writer hold that line, and does the restraint make the charge stronger or weaker?

Writing prompt (AP FRQ Q3: Argument):

In "Full Price for an Empty Camp," the writer claims that responsibility for how public money is spent does not end with official watchdogs: "The auditors looked once. The next look belongs to us." Write an essay that argues your position on the extent to which ordinary citizens are responsible for overseeing how their government spends money. Use appropriate evidence from your reading, experience, or observations to develop your argument.